Pressure Gradient Theory: Deriving Fundamental Constants from Tetrahedral Vacuum Geometry

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Abstract. Pressure Gradient Theory (PGT) proposes that the vacuum is a high-pressure lattice of regular tetrahedra in face-centered cubic (FCC) close packing. From three axioms and the geometry of tetrahedral stacking, we derive the fine-structure constant $\alpha^{-1} = 360°/\delta_S - 5\delta_S = 137.046$ (error +0.007%), the proton-to-electron mass ratio $\mu = \alpha^{-1}(12+\sqrt{2}) - 20u_k = 1836.03$ (error −0.007%), and the Planck-to-nuclear hierarchy $12 \times \delta_S^{42} = 1.43 \times 10^{17}$ (error +0.15%), where $\delta_S = 1+\sqrt{2}$ (silver ratio) is a zero-input geometric constant from the stacking constraint $x^2 = 2x + 1$. A revised CP violation formula $\varepsilon_K = \sin(\Delta T)/(6\pi) = 0.002235$ matches experiment to 0.3%. We present a structural formula $G = 12\hbar^2 H_0/(c\, m_\pi^3)$ connecting gravity to quantum, cosmological, and particle-physics scales, and resolve the cosmological constant problem conceptually by distinguishing vacuum stiffness from low-frequency elastic response. Conservative input count: 3–5 parameters versus 25 in the Standard Model.

Part I: Cracks in Mainstream Physics

1. Decomposing the Gravitational Constant

1.1 What is hidden inside G?

Newton's gravitational constant $G = 6.674 \times 10^{-11}$ m^3/(kg s^2) remains one of the least precisely measured fundamental constants. More troubling: no mainstream theory explains *why* G takes this value.

Dimensional analysis reveals that $[G] = [\mathrm{m}^3/(\mathrm{kg}\cdot\mathrm{s}^2)]$ can be assembled as

$$G = N \cdot \frac{\hbar^2 H_0}{c\, m_\pi^3} \tag{1}$$

where $\hbar$ is the reduced Planck constant, H_0 the Hubble parameter, c the speed of light, m_π the pion mass, and N an integer. Setting $N = 12$ yields

$$G_{\mathrm{PGT}} = \frac{12\,\hbar^2 H_0}{c\, m_\pi^3} = 6.670 \times 10^{-11}\ \mathrm{m}^3/(\mathrm{kg}\cdot\mathrm{s}^2) \tag{2}$$

matching the measured value. The integer 12 equals the FCC close-packing coordination number.

1.2 Cross-scale connection

Equation (1) links three supposedly unrelated domains:

Factor	Scale	Domain
$\hbar$	10^{-34} J·s	Quantum mechanics
H_0	10^{-18} s^{-1}	Cosmology
m_π	10^{-28} kg	Strong interaction
c	10^8 m/s	Relativity

If G genuinely decomposes this way, gravity is not an independent force—it is a geometric combination of quantum, cosmological, and hadronic scales.

Back-calculating H_0:

$$H_0 = \frac{G\, c\, m_\pi^3}{12\hbar^2} = 71.3\ \mathrm{km/s/Mpc} \tag{3}$$

which falls between the SH0ES measurement (73.0) and Planck inference (67.4), squarely within the Hubble tension window.

2. The True Origin of Forces

2.1 Pressure gradients as the universal mechanism

If the vacuum is a high-pressure medium, all forces reduce to pressure gradients:

$$\mathbf{F} = -V\,\nabla P \tag{4}$$

- **Gravity**: pressure shielding—mass particles occlude vacuum pressure; external pressure pushes them together.
- **Electromagnetism**: chiral polarization asymmetry in the medium.
- **Strong force**: three-phase pressure equilibrium (Plateau's law, 120° junctions = 360°/3).
- **Weak force**: rare chirality-flip events in the medium.

A discrete lattice medium bypasses the fatal flaw of classical aether: the speed of light equals the lattice sound speed and is frame-independent, because observers themselves are lattice excitations.

3. The Cosmological Constant Problem

Quantum field theory predicts $\rho_{\text{vac}} \sim 10^{93}$ g/cm^3. Observation gives $\rho_\Lambda \sim 10^{-29}$ g/cm^3—a discrepancy of 10^{122}.

The resolution: these are *different physical quantities*.

Quantity	Meaning	Magnitude
P_{vac}	Vacuum stiffness	$\sim 10^{113}$ J/m^3
ρ_Λ	Low-freq. response	$\sim 10^{-9}$ J/m^3

Analogy: the bulk modulus of steel ($\sim 10^{11}$ Pa) differs from the energy density of seismic waves in steel ($\sim 10^2$ J/m^3) by $\sim 10^9$—nobody calls this the "steel modulus problem." The 120-order discrepancy is *correct* because P_{vac} and ρ_Λ were never the same quantity.

4. Ten Unsolved Problems: Brief Solutions

Table 1 summarizes solutions within the pressure-medium framework.

The ten solutions are summarized in Table 1.

Table 1: Precision summary of PGT solutions.

Result	Error	Grade
$\alpha^{-1} = 137.046$	+0.007%	A
$\mu = 1836.03$	−0.007%	A
$12\delta_S^{42} = 1.43\times10^{17}$	+0.15%	A
$\varepsilon_K = 0.002235$	+0.3%	B
CC: $P_{\text{vac}} \neq \rho_\Lambda$	concept	B
$H_0 = 71.3$	intermed.	B
$G = 12\hbar^2 H_0/(cm_\pi^3)$	dep. H_0	B
3 generations	qualit.	C
Dark matter	framework	Dev.
Quantum gravity	concept	Dev.

A = rigorous, $< 0.1\%$. B = complete, $< 1\%$ or conceptual. C = framework. Dev. = in development.

Part II: Pressure Gradient Theory

5. Axioms

A1 (Lattice Structure). The vacuum is a high-pressure lattice of regular tetrahedra in face-to-face close packing, with macroscopic FCC structure:

$$P_{\text{vac}} = 12 \cdot 6\sqrt{2}\,\frac{\hbar c}{\ell_0^4} \tag{5}$$

where ℓ_0 is the lattice constant. Light speed $c = \sqrt{K/\rho}$ is the lattice sound speed; $\hbar$ is a derived quantity, not independent.

A2 (Stacking Constraint). Face-to-face tetrahedral stacking produces a unique chiral structure: the Boerdijk–Coxeter (BC) helix, with twist angle

$$T_{\text{twist}} = 60^\circ + \delta_S^\circ = 62.414^\circ \tag{6}$$

where $\delta_S = 1 + \sqrt{2} = 2.41421\ldots$ is the silver ratio, the positive root of $x^2 = 2x + 1$—an algebraic necessity of the stacking geometry.

Tetrahedral stacking simultaneously generates: (i) the FCC lattice (macroscopic), (ii)

the BC helix (1D chiral propagation), and (iii) icosahedral order (local 12-neighbor arrangement). These are three facets of a single geometric operation.

A3 (Constant Pressure). P_{vac} is the elastic modulus of the lattice—constant and immutable.

6. Core Geometric Parameters

All geometric constants below are zero-input—they follow automatically from "regular tetrahedron":

Constant	Value	Origin
$\delta_S = 1 + \sqrt{2}$	2.41421	$x^2 = 2x + 1$
$N = 12$	12	FCC coordination
20	20	Icosahedral faces
$\sqrt{2}$	1.41421	FCC face diagonal
5	5	$\lfloor 360°/70.53° \rfloor$
16	16	$(V+F) \times$ chirality
42	42	Mackay shell $10 \times 2^2 + 2$

6.1 Why 5 is inevitable

The tetrahedral dihedral angle is $\theta_d = \arccos(1/3) = 70.529°$. Around a shared edge, at most $\lfloor 360°/70.53° \rfloor = 5$ tetrahedra fit; the sixth exceeds 360°.

By the close-packing principle, $n = 5$ (maximum filling, minimum gap of 7.36°) is the lowest-energy configuration. Among $n \in \{1, 2, 3, 4, 5\}$, only $n = 5$ yields $\alpha^{-1} = 137.046$ within 0.1%; $n = 4$ deviates by 1.8%.

Three independent paths—geometric upper bound, energy minimization, experimental elimination—converge on $n = 5$.

6.2 Why 16

A regular tetrahedron has 4 vertices (pressure contact points) + 4 faces (chirality interfaces) = 8 ports. Each port has 2 chiral states $\Rightarrow$ $8 \times 2 = 16$.

Consistency: $E \times$ chirality $= 6 \times 2 = 12 =$ FCC coordination number.

6.3 Geometric viscosity u_k

$$u_k(\text{Step}) = 16/\alpha^{-1} \approx 0.1168 \quad \text{(discrete/3D)} \tag{7}$$

$$u_k(\text{Angle}) = \Phi_{\text{gap}}/T_{\text{twist}} \approx 0.1179 \quad \text{(continuous/2D)} \tag{8}$$

The 0.92% difference is the 2D↔3D projection residual.

7. Fine-Structure Constant

The BC helix rotates $\Delta T = \delta_S^\circ$ per step. Ideal closure requires $N_{\text{ideal}} = 360°/\delta_S = 149.117$ steps. Subtracting the five-fold topological debt:

$$\boxed{\alpha^{-1} = \frac{360°}{\delta_S} - 5\delta_S = 137.046} \tag{9}$$

Experimental: 137.035999206 **Error:** +0.007%

The electromagnetic coupling constant equals the effective refresh period of the BC helix.

8. Proton-to-Electron Mass Ratio

$$\boxed{\mu = \alpha^{-1}(12 + \sqrt{2}) - 20\, u_k = 1836.03} \tag{10}$$

Experimental: 1836.15267 **Error:** −0.007%

Factor decomposition: $\alpha^{-1} \times 12 =$ EM refresh $\times$ nearest-neighbor count; $\alpha^{-1} \times \sqrt{2} =$ FCC diagonal tension; $-20u_k =$ chiral viscosity across 20 icosahedral faces.

9. The Hierarchy Problem

$$\boxed{\frac{\ell_0}{\ell_{\text{P}}} = 12 \times \delta_S^{42} = 1.4314 \times 10^{17}} \tag{11}$$

Observed: 1.4292×10^{17} **Error:** +0.15%

Gravity is weak because signals traverse 42 chiral shell layers, each attenuated by δ_S.

10. Gravitational Constant

$$\boxed{G = \frac{12\hbar^2 H_0}{c\, m_\pi^3}} \tag{12}$$

G and H_0 mutually define each other. Back-calculated $H_0 = 71.3$ km/s/Mpc falls between the Hubble tension values.

Precision note: Using $H_0 = 73$ (SH0ES) gives +2.45% error. The 0.36% claimed in v6.0 was a rounding artifact; corrected here.

11. CP Violation

11.1 Chirality mechanism

The BC helix chiral impedance asymmetry is

$$\sin(\Delta T) = \sin(2.414^\circ) = 0.04212 \approx 4.2\% \tag{13}$$

11.2 Kaon ε_K (v6.2 revised)

$$\boxed{\varepsilon_K = \frac{\sin(\Delta T)}{6\pi} = \frac{\sin(\Delta T)}{N_{\text{color}} \times 2\pi} = 0.002235} \tag{14}$$

Experimental: 0.002228 **Error:** +0.3%

The v6.0 formula $20\sin(\Delta T)/(2\pi) = 0.134$ was off by 60× and has been replaced. The color factor 1/3 derives from Plateau's three-interface equilibrium.

11.3 Jarlskog invariant

$J = \sin^3(\Delta T)\cos(\Delta T)/3 = 2.49 \times 10^{-5}$ versus experimental 3.08×10^{-5} (19% off; Tier 2).

11.4 Baryon asymmetry η

Conceptual pathway clear; quantitative derivation off by orders of magnitude. **Tier 3.**

12. Electron Anomalous Magnetic Moment

$$a_e = \frac{\alpha}{2\pi} = 0.001161 \tag{15}$$

Experimental: 0.001160 **Error:** +0.15%

Not original (Schwinger 1948); PGT provides geometric interpretation: single BC-helix cycle coupling correction.

13. Cosmology

13.1 Cosmological constant

$P_{\text{vac}} \neq \rho_\Lambda$: conceptual resolution of the 10^{120} problem. Quantitative $\rho_\Lambda(\text{PGT}) \approx 9.8 \times 10^{-27}$ kg/m^3 versus observed 6.9×10^{-27} (42% off, not independent).

13.2 Hubble tension

$H_0(\text{PGT}) = 71.3$ km/s/Mpc. Redshift mechanism: photon energy attenuation in the lattice (not spatial expansion). The v6.0 formula $H(z) = 73/(1+z)^{0.118}$ fails at $z = 1100$ by 52%. Full cosmological model under development. **Tier 3.**

14. Three Generations of Fermions

Three independent excitation modes of a regular tetrahedron: vertex (1st generation), edge (2nd), face (3rd). Fourth generation = whole-body excitation = global chirality flip = unobservable. **Tier 2**; quantitative mass ratios to be derived.

15. Unified Field Equation

$$\Delta P_{\text{drive}} = \nabla P_{\text{shield}} - \eta_{\text{geom}} \frac{\partial P}{\partial t} + R(t) \tag{16}$$

where ∇P_{shield} gives static forces (gravity, Coulomb), $\eta_{\text{geom}}\, \partial_t P$ gives inertial/radiation damping, and $R(t)$ is chiral-slip noise (quantum stochasticity). All four forces are special cases. Explicit limit recoveries remain the primary open work.

16. Input Parameters

Type	Count	Notes
Geometric constants	0	$\delta_S, 12, 20, \sqrt{2}, 5, 16, 42$
Physical parameters	3–5	ℓ_0 (or $\hbar$), c, m_e, $[m_\pi]$, $[H_0]$
Standard Model	25	19 particle + 6 cosmological

Conservative: $25 \to 5 =$ **80% reduction**.

17. Falsifiable Predictions

Near-term testable:

1. $H_0 = 71.3$ km/s/Mpc (DESI, Euclid, Roman)
2. Tolman surface brightness: $(1+z)^2$ vs. $(1+z)^4$ (JWST)
3. $\varepsilon_K = 0.002235$ (verified to 0.3%)

Falsification conditions:

- α^{-1} cannot be expressed as $360/\delta_S - n\delta_S$ for integer n
- G is perfectly constant across all environments
- A fourth fermion generation is discovered
- Tolman test confirms $(1+z)^4$ (expanding-space model)

A. Numerical Verification

Formula	PGT	Exp.	Error
α^{-1}	137.046	137.036	+0.007%
μ	1836.03	1836.15	−0.007%
$12\delta_S^{42}$	1.431×10^{17}	1.429×10^{17}	+0.15%
a_e	0.001161	0.001160	+0.15%
ε_K	0.002235	0.002228	+0.3%
H_0	71.3	67.4–73.0	Intermediate

Python verification code is available in the supplementary materials.

B. Dimensional Analysis

Formula	Dimensions
$\alpha^{-1} = 360°/\delta_S - 5\delta_S$	Dimensionless ✓
$\mu = \alpha^{-1}(12+\sqrt{2}) - 20u_k$	Dimensionless ✓
$G = 12\hbar^2 H_0/(cm_\pi^3)$	$\mathrm{m}^3/(\mathrm{kg\,s}^2)$ ✓
$P_{\mathrm{vac}} = 12\cdot 6\sqrt{2}\,\hbar c/\ell_0^4$	Pa ✓
$\varepsilon_K = \sin(\Delta T)/(6\pi)$	Dimensionless ✓

C. BC Helix Geometry

The BC helix axial rotation angle from the literature is $\arccos(-2/3) = 131.81°$. Its relation to $T_{\mathrm{twist}} = 62.41°$:

$$\arccos(-2/3) \approx 120° + 5\delta_S \qquad (0.2\% \text{ residual}) \tag{17}$$

Decomposition: axial rotation = 2× face angle (60°)+ five-fold topological correction ($5\delta_S$).

This places $5\delta_S$ concretely in the 3D helical geometry as the residual after subtracting base face angles—the projection of five-tetrahedra ring frustration onto the helix axis.

D. Completeness Grades

Grade	Criterion	Formulas
A	Rigorous, $< 0.1\%$	α^{-1}, μ, hierarchy
B	Complete, $< 1\%$	ε_K, a_e, G, ρ_Λ
C	Framework	J, 3 generations
Dev.	Concept only	η, Hubble, DM, QG

E. Revision Log: v6.0 → v6.2

Item	v6.0	v6.2
G error	0.36%	Dep. on H_0
ε_K	0.134 (60× off)	0.002235
Factor	Icosa. faces	Color (1/3)
Origin of 5	Incomplete	Close-packing
Origin of 16	4×4	$(V+F)$×chiral
Params	2 claimed	Honest 3–5
$H(z)$	Tier 1	Tier 3
Baryon η	"Solved"	Tier 3
Euler χ	$V=21$	Deleted

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